A Computer That Learns From Old Storms Guessed Right

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When the first hurricane of this Atlantic season formed, a computer that learns from history did a better job than older models at guessing where it would go. In early October, Hurricane Isaias came ashore near Destin, Florida, as a **Category 2** storm. Older models first said it would go farther west, toward southeastern Louisiana. But Google DeepMind's **artificial intelligence** model got it right from the start: it would hit the western Florida **Panhandle**. **Meteorologist** Michael Lowry calls DeepMind the gold standard model. He says it has been by far the best computer model **forecasters** have ever seen. Old models use live data and hard math to work out a storm's path and strength. The new AI model looks for patterns in thousands of old storms. The Hurricane Center still mixes several models together, and people read the results before telling the public.

Word Treasure

artificial intelligence -- Artificial intelligence is a computer system that learns from data to do tasks that usually need human thinking.

Meteorologist -- A meteorologist is a scientist who studies weather and predicts storms.

Panhandle -- The Florida Panhandle is the long, narrow strip of land in the northwest part of Florida.

forecasters -- Forecasters are people who predict what the weather will do.

Category 2 -- Category 2 is a label for a hurricane of a certain strength.

Background you need

Forecasters use computer models to guess where a hurricane will go and how strong it will be.

Older models use live weather data and math, while the new AI model looks for patterns in thousands of old storms.

Forecasters mix several models together and check the results before telling the public.

Break it down

WHO: Google DeepMind's artificial intelligence model, older computer models, meteorologist Michael Lowry, and Hurricane Center forecasters

WHAT: The AI model correctly predicted where Hurricane Isaias would hit, beating older models

WHERE: Near Destin, Florida, in the western Florida Panhandle

WHY: The AI model learned from patterns in thousands of old storms while older models first pointed farther west

Why it matters

Better storm predictions help families know when to stay safe or leave home before a hurricane arrives.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of storm is this story about?

- (A) A tornado
- (B) Hurricane Isaias
- (C) A winter snowstorm
- (D) A flood

2. Where did Hurricane Isaias come ashore?

- (A) In southeastern Louisiana
- (B) In northern California
- (C) Near Miami, Florida
- (D) Near Destin, Florida

3. What did Google DeepMind's AI model get right from the start?

- (A) It would weaken to light rain
- (B) It would turn back out to sea
- (C) It would hit the western Florida Panhandle
- (D) It would hit Louisiana

4. How does the new AI model work?

- (A) It looks for patterns in thousands of old storms
- (B) It asks people on the beach
- (C) It guesses without using any data
- (D) It follows one storm by boat

5. What does Michael Lowry call DeepMind?

- (A) The last model
- (B) The oldest model
- (C) The slowest model
- (D) The gold standard model

6. What does the Hurricane Center still do?

- (A) It uses only the AI model
- (B) It waits until storms have passed
- (C) It mixes several models together
- (D) It stops forecasting in October

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Meteorologist Michael Lowry: He calls DeepMind the gold standard model and says it has been by far the best computer model forecasters have ever seen.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):